

Q. You have had a very uneasy relationship with the media.

A. Unfortunately, Indian politics today has become very media-centric. In fact, politicians have found shortcuts to political growth through the media. Some of them survive only because of media management. I am not into this game.

Q. When you took over as chief minister six years ago, you had no experience of electoral politics and administration. Now you are recognised as a good administrator.

A. I have worked with the same system and the set of bureaucrats that have been in place for years. The message is that if you have the will, determination and vision, you can succeed in governance.

Q. Why are you so misunderstood?

A. Democracy gives you the power to criticise and debate. But I am the target of allegations and not honest, democratic criticism.

Q. What will be the impact of BJP's victory in Gujarat on the UPA-led Union Government?

A. The Government in Delhi is

WILL NOW GROW BOLDER DIFFICULT TO MEET."

literally working on daily wages. Our win in Gujarat will spur its disintegration. The non-Congress constituents of UPA will grow bolder in their demands, which it will be hard put to meet.

Q. You claim to have controlled terrorism in Gujarat to a large extent when it is increasing in other parts of the country. What do you think of the anti-terror measures taken by the Congress-led UPA Government?

A. The Congress has committed the sin of turning India into a soft state against terrorism for the sake of its vote-bank politics. It has refused to hang Afzal Guru, removed POTA, compromised with Naxalites in Andhra Pradesh and with ULFA in Assam for the sake of votes. The war against terror can't be selective. The need of the hour is to bring all human forces on one platform against terrorism.

sweeter. Not only did he manage a near-two-third majority in what was predicted to be a neck-and-neck race, he also ensured the decimation of all except one of the 29 BJP rebels, including seven who fought on Congress tickets. Similarly, while almost half of the 26-member Cabinet was expected to lose to anti-incumbency, only seven lost. The most surprising victory was in Saurashtra-Kutch, the stronghold of the BJP rebels led by Keshubhai Patel, Gordhan Jhadaphiya and former chief minister Suresh Mehta, where BJP won 43 of the 58 seats.

However, in central Gujarat, where the communal polarisation brought about by the riots in 2002 saw BJP sweeping the region in the last elections, the party suffered a setback, with its tally of 38 sliding down to 18 as the region went back to the Congress. In the rest of the state, however, it was a Modi wave.

THE ONE-MAN ARMY

Behind these impressive figures is the man himself. However much he may deny it now, Modi the individual was the overriding factor, his personality and undoubted charisma and the clever invocation of Gujarati pride far outweighed caste, community, incumbency, dissidence, level of opposition, party affiliation and inputs from the Central leadership. This was a victory by a one-man army. Modi campaigned like a man possessed, addressing nearly 200 poll meetings across the state in a span of 17 days, alternately by chopper and a converted Toyota Land Cruiser. He campaigned for an average 14 hours a day and though local and party leaders from outside addressed nearly 400 public meetings in the state, it was clearly a Modi show.

HOW MODI CRAFTED THE WIN

Mapping Modi's spectacular victory, credit must be given to his planning, and to the many Government-sponsored schemes and meetings that were converted into political rallies. Modi had finalised his electoral plans by the middle of last year, focusing on four major voting groups—women, youth, tribals and fishermen. Fishermen number high in the state that has the country's longest coastline.

Women, youth and tribals together constitute a substantial percentage of the voting population. So, by October 10, when elections were announced, he had already completed the first round of his campaigning at the Government's expense by holding around 50 public meetings and directly addressing over 40 lakh people from his target vote bank in a span of just over three months. In these meetings, he gave them a rundown of his developmental achievements.

It worked. The youth and women came out to vote for him in large numbers. Modi addressed around 18 lakh women in about 27 all-women rallies, in which he talked about his drive against female infanticide in the name of Beti Bachao Andolan (save the girl child) and how it had changed the state's sex ratio from 802 to 870, for every 1,000 males, in his six-year tenure. He also talked of his drive to educate girls, which had brought down the female drop-out rate from 48 to three and emphasised his agenda for the social empowerment of women.

For the tribals and fishermen, Modi floated the Rs 15,000-crore Vanbandhu Yojna (tribal welfare scheme) and the Rs 11,000-crore Sagarkhedu Yojna (fishermen's welfare scheme) in March-April last year. The chief minister addressed six tribal rallies and four fishermen's rallies between August 9 and October 10 this year. The rallies, which were organised with active Government support, effectively neutralised anti-incumbency at the grassroots level.

Modi then launched the Vanthanbhi Vikas Yatra to gauge the mood of the rural populace. His ministers visited 4,000 villages in a span of just 40 days on the pretext of inaugurating developmental work already completed. That not a single minister received a hostile reaction from any of these villages reassured him—his Government was not facing an anti-incumbency wave.

Finally, a pre-electoral survey was carried out at the behest of BJP's central leadership in October. The results removed any doubts in Modi's mind about his electoral chances. The survey showed that Modi had over 80 per cent acceptability amongst the people based on his own image—that of an incor-